

Correspondence

FROM Dr. George M. Ella
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Dear Sir,

The **Theologoumena Pantadapa** is an absolute must and it was highly stimulating to read the background material on Owen and his works in Issue No. 16. In connection with this, I would like to comment on Jim Packer's remark that some of the learning revealed in Owen's research is "inevitably out of date." In Hebrew studies 'out of date' often means 'out of sight is out of mind' as there is perhaps no branch of linguistics which has been so neglected as this. Owing to the tendency of Liberal theologians to accept any myth that might discredit the antiquity of the Scriptures and their testimony, true scientific research into Biblical Hebrew has hardly progressed since the days of Owen.

Though the work of the Tiberian Massoretic scribes, which is dated later and later as Liberal theology develops, is taken as the cradle of Hebrew vocalization, it may interest readers to know that 17th and 18th century Hebrew scholars rejected the idea of a Massoretic origin of vowel pointing on the grounds that the Tiberians were not skilled enough in linguistics and could never have spontaneously created such a precise and perfect system as that used in the Holy Scriptures. They rejected the Massoretic theory, along with the up-and-coming evolutionary ideas of history and linguistic development as unscientific and developed by people who put a belief in fables before hard study. The results of their research showed that the Massoretic pointing was either taken over from or based on much older forms. Bishop Ussher, for instance, believed that Ezra re-pointed the Hebrew text of the Jewish Bible on the Jews return from (exile in) Babylon around BC 454, arguing that there was a form (of vowel pointing) even before that.

I became familiar with Owen's teaching on (Hebrew Vowel pointing) in the sixties whilst studying Hebrew under Ringren, Magnusson, and Erlandson at Uppsala University. I found out then that all the evidence regarding vocalization was on Owen's side. Obviously the main evidence for Owen's teaching is to be found in Scripture. Jesus said unmistakably in Matt. 5:18, "Till heaven and earth pass away, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled." Here, Jesus refers to two separate letters in the Old Testament canon, the jot or yodh, which is the smallest consonant in Hebrew (used roughly equivalent to our "y" sound. Ed.), and the tittle or keraia, which is the smallest vocalization letter or sign. Pioneering linguistic laws which became known in a modified form as Grimms' Law (after the Grimm brothers) half a century later, Dr. John Gill showed that the Greek keraia was the Hebrew vowel sound Hireq (transcribed Chirek by Gill) or dot which formed the basis of all Hebrew vowel pointing. Besides using internal evidence and his enormous linguistic acumen, Gill produced a mass of archaeological, numismatic, and documentary evidence to prove the antiquity of the Hebrew points.

Arguing from supposed Massoretic times when pointing was allegedly invented, Gill shows that points were in general use at the time and even printed versions of vocalized Bibles were in circulation. This information was laughed at by later source critics who were ignorant of the fact that Bibles printed in page-blocks were known for centuries before moveable type was invented. Then, continuing to probe backwards to the time of the Prophets through the works of Ben Asher, Ben Naphtali, Saadia Baon, Jerome, Rabbi Ase, the Sura Academy, the Rabbot, the Jerusalem Talmud, Origen's Hexapla, Irenaeus, Clement of Alexandria, the Jonathan and Onkelos Targums, Josephus,